

Scandiman

A Pac-man clone with Nordic words involved

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GAME IDEA

- *An adventurer is collecting letters in a maze in order to solve a puzzle while avoiding ghosts roaming the maze. In this Pac-man clone, the purpose is to impose the players with Nordic words to help to investigate similarities and differences between the languages.*

GAME OBJECTIVE

MAIN OBJECTIVE

- *Ludic objective*
 - *to make a simple platformer with a pick-and-choose difficulty*
- *Serious objective*
 - *to help the players not to confuse (me with other) Nordic languages (/cultures)*
- *Design objective*
 - *to create a basis for Nordic-language based game that could work as a foundation for the more complex design idea with the same premise*
- *Course objective*
 - *to learn how to use Godot with a simple project that allows flexibility when features are more familiar/comfortable*

GAMEPLAY GOAL/S

- *I want the players to experience a Pac Man with word hunting*
- *I would like to players to feel “ahaa” moments when they connect words with hints*
 - *I expect the player to be frustrated with the design choices, as per usual with my games*
- *The game is simple and casual*
 - *difficulty relies on how familiar the player is with the words and randomness of the enemy position*
 - *unlike in the reference game, the plan is not to make enemies to move faster as levels progress, as it would defeat the purpose of learning and familiarize with the word*
 - *the difficulty comes from the pointification; extra points are rewarded, if letters are collected in the correct order*
- *Ideally, the player is encouraged to choose different languages, increasing the replayability*

PRESENTATION GOAL/S

- *Presentation goal: simplistic and naive*
- *The players should feel relaxed, casual, and lighthearted*
- *In full-devolved version, a Nintendo-esque vibe*
- *In my current skill level, players should have a smile at least once*

GENRE

- *MMORPG reverse metroidvania ice hockey simulator with tamagotchi elements*
- *More seriously: 2D top-view singleplayer single-screen maze chase word puzzle*
 - *in my childhood, there were two similar games where a pac-man-esque token collected letters or letters in (reverse) order*
 - *I do not find the references for those, and even Gemini had issues to locate Finnish MS-DOS CD-ROM games from 90s*

TARGET AUDIENCE

- *core target audience: people interested to integrate into Nordic countries*
 - *the game has a high-road transfer attempt to help people to use Nordic as the general term instead of Scandinavia, as it can refer the geographical location or language area*
 - *it lowers the threshold to learn the languages through connecting the similarities and alphabetical differences*
 - *as the plan is not to mix the different language words in a puzzle (yet), the game works also as an introduction to the alphabet and words*
- *minor target audience: people from Nordic bubble interested of their neighbors*
 - *a playful way to make the Nordic people to see how other languages are spelling the words*
 - *Danish, Norwegian and Swedish: comparison with the similarities in words and alphabets*
 - *Finnish: exploring how differently the other language family branch takes the words*

PLATFORM

- *Online – Internet Browser (itch.io)*
 - *keyboard and USB-controller support*
 - *no plans to make a touch screen support*

SUMMARY

- *A pac-man clone where the player collects the letters to spell the Nordic words in 10 different levels. The player continues to the next level when they collect the letters. The game ends when the player finishes the 10th level or the enemies have caught the player 3 times.*
- *The player first chooses the language they want to play (Danish, Norwegian, Swedish, or Finnish). The first 5 levels are focused on numbers 1 to 5. The last 5 levels are focused on different words.*
- *The game could be presented in an Indiana Jones -style, so the player is navigating in a maze, solving an ancient puzzle to open a door to the next chamber. In the end, a treasure could wait.*
 - *The last level could be an temple run styled escape scene where the player must spell the word before the level ends*
 - *This is seen as a wish list for the future development*

GAMEPLAY

MECHANICS

- *Navigate*
 - *the menu to*
 - *start a new game*
 - *select a language*
 - *see credits*
- *Select*
 - *items in the menu to perform the navigated task*
- *Move*
 - *up, down, left, right to*
 - *navigate the maze*
 - *avoid enemies*
- *Collect*
 - *letters to*
 - *spell the word to finish the level*
 - *collect points to get the arcade-feeling*
 - *a temporary power-up to*
 - *repel enemies for few seconds*

FEATURES

- *4 Nordic languages (Danish, Norwegian, Swedish, and Finnish)*
 - *thanks to my last year's Scandi-durak prototype, I have a list of 15 words plus the numbers from 1 to 5 for each 4 language*
 - *the prototype had own power scale which can be utilized for the difficulty curve in the second half of the game*
 - *there is a potential to expand the material with other Nordic languages (for example Icelandic)*

PRESENTATION

TEXT

- *hints are pictures, words are in the chosen languages*
- *Everything else (menu, UI etc): simple, English and easy to translate*

VISUAL

- *3 enemy ghosts could have colors of the non-chosen Nordic language's flags*
 - *the chasing ghost could have the flag that was strong against the chosen language in the Scandi-durak power dynamic*
 - *Note: Finnish had weakness to itself while playing neutral with others*
 - *This can transmute into all ghost being non-chasers in Finnish language, which balances that Finnish words are often longer, more different and more complex than others*

AUDIO

- *ideally, background music in a maze would mimic the Nordic culture one way or another, for example:*
 - *Swedish: an Abba song in the background*
 - *Danish: research this, cannot be Barbie Girl*
 - *Norwegian: most likely "In the Hall of the Mountain King" but it would be fun to have a Dimmu Borgir song*
 - *Finnish: Finlandia would be boring, Sandstorm and Hard Rock Hallelujah are strong in their own ways*
- *most likely: a public domain song composed by someone from each represented Nordic country*

DEVELOPMENT SCHEDULE

- *A simple, playable prototype should be able to do within the course's schedule*
 - *A vertical sliced whitebox?*
- *This section will be updated when I have a bigger understanding how the course is phased and structured*
- *As a placeholder schedule, when a sprint is assumed to be 2 weeks long:*
 - *Sprint 1: Pac-man logic and tile mapping working*
 - *Sprint 2: All 10 levels with a set of language working*
 - *Sprint 3: All intended languages implemented with the placeholder assets*
 - *Sprint 4: Polishing the whitebox presentation*

POSSIBLE HURDLES

- *Scheduling issues*
 - *clashes with other courses, such as*
 - *complex assignments that take longer time*
 - *writing thesis*
 - *meetings*
- *My learning path with Godot*
- *My skill hiccups when it comes to programming*
- *Update more here when something else comes to mind*

Appendix A: Core Loop